

Learning outcomes and assessment

Learning Outcomes are statements of what a learner will learn over a defined period. They are used to guide learners, but they are also essential for providing the basis for what will be taught, and what will be assessed.

The following guide offers some prompts for developing learning outcomes for Community Engaged Learning (CEL).

Step 1. Scope

We recommend you start by identifying the module's objectives. Consider what knowledge, skills, and attitudes you want students to gain from the experience.

Ensure that the learning outcomes align with the course content. Identify specific topics, themes, or concepts from the course material that can be reinforced or enhanced through CEL activities.

These objectives should reflect both the broader goals of community engagement and partnership needs. If possible, engage with relevant stakeholders, including community partners, students, and staff, to gather input and perspectives on the module.

If community partners are involved in teaching, it is typically good practice to ensure the relevant learning outcomes are co-designed with them.

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THIS PAPER OFFERS VALUABLE
INSIGHT INTO THE CO-DESIGN
PROCESS.



From our review of CEL, we identified the following goals that are specific to CEL, that you might like to consider:

- **Professional and technical capabilities:** weaving academic and technical knowledge into students' professional identities. For example, level 4 learning outcome: "By the end of the course/module, students will be able to recognise foundational academic principles and technical skills relevant to their field of study."
- **Civic and citizenship:** developing students' capabilities to engage in the world and apply their knowledge to make it a better place. For example, level 5 learning outcome: "By the end of the course/module, students will be able to apply their knowledge to real life scenarios".
- **Personal attributes:** helping students to develop healthy habits of thinking, feeling and being. For example, level 7 learning outcome: By the end of the module/course, students will be able to analyse, evaluate, and synthesise their thoughts and emotions in relation to sustainability issues such as poverty before they employ action."

Step2. Develop

Write learning outcomes using clear and measurable action verbs that describe the specific behaviours or actions students are expected to demonstrate.

Common action verbs used in learning outcomes include analyse, evaluate, create, apply, collaborate, communicate, and reflect.

We have included some examples in the next section. A common taxonomy used in the sector is Bloom's Taxonomy.

Reflect on the outcomes for community partners. Learning outcomes should reflect community engagement goals, such as promoting social justice, addressing community needs, fostering civic responsibility, and promoting sustainable change.

The outcomes should align with the benefits that communities are seeking to derive from partnering with you.



Below we provide some examples learning outcomes. Many of these could be further improved:

Professional and technical capabilities

- Demonstrates an ability to work collaboratively within interdisciplinary teams
- Capacity to undertake participatory engagement with clients, learning from them, adapting to their feedback and sharing ownership of a project.
- Demonstrates a capability to manage emergent ambiguities in risk exposure and decision-making.
- Demonstrate a high level of achievement in project management skills, including structuring tasks, prioritising, showing initiative and delivering on time.
- Demonstrated in writing that they have experienced situations in which they have applied academic knowledge to the practical tasks they have been set and completed.
- Apply creative problem-solving and develop self-reflective and critical thinking.
- Learn to translate planning objectives and context specific analysis.
- Reflect on the appropriate skills needed to support the aims and objectives of specific community and voluntary contexts.
- Deliver your report in an appropriate format that address the needs of your audience and accepted academic norms.
- Ability to select appropriate interventions and related evidence

Civic, social and citizenship

- A critical awareness of civic and cultural identity in the region, and the factors that influence it.
- Evidence of your capacity to understand the political, economic, social, environmental, and cultural contexts of the area.
- Accurate knowledge of the local area gained not just from basic statistics but from any combination of local sources such as community organisations' websites, local news, surveys, site visits, interviews, observations.
- A competent understanding of the possibility and limitations of community engagement and what it can or cannot include.
- Demonstrates evidence of adjustments in own values and beliefs following experiences of working with communities.

Personal attributes

- Demonstrates leadership, teamwork and independent study skills, and the ability to conduct independent primary source research for essays.
- Tailors' communication strategies to effectively listen, express and adapt to others.
- Critically evaluate own behaviour and that of others.
- Demonstrate written evidence of effective group-work with respect to both 'task' roles and group maintenance (no one left behind).
- Sustained evidence of ability to exercise critical thinking, self-understanding and learning.

Step3. Review

Ensure that learning outcomes are measurable and assessable. Define criteria or indicators that can be used to evaluate students' achievement of the learning outcomes, whether through assignments, assessments, reflections, or other means. We have included some further examples in the next section.

Review the learning outcomes with relevant stakeholders to ensure clarity, relevance, and feasibility. Based on feedback and input from stakeholders, revise and refine the learning outcomes as needed.

By following these steps, you can develop clear, meaningful, and measurable learning outcomes that align with the objectives of CEL and contribute to meaningful student learning experiences.



Activity: Framework Review

Review this framework developed by one of our course designers to help you reflect on and your learning outcomes.

EMBEDDING PUBLIC ENGAGEMENT IN THE CURRICULUM: A
FRAMEWORK FOR THE ASSESSMENT OF STUDENT
LEARNING FROM PUBLIC ENGAGEMENT

